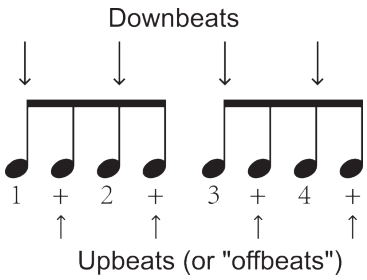
LESSON 4: DOWNBEATS, UPBEATS, AND SYNCOPATION

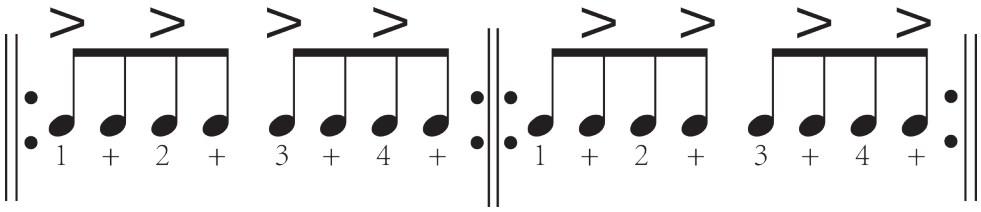
Counts 1, 2, 3, and 4 are considered **downbeats**. The eighth notes that occur in between them (the “ands”) are considered **upbeats**. Accenting the downbeats can create a “stompy” or “driving” feel, while accenting the upbeats can create a “bouncy” or “funky” sound that is called **syncopation**.



In this exercise you’ll choose an easy open chord (like E) and then strum it for two measures using only eighth notes while accenting the downbeats. Then you’ll do it again, but switch to accenting the upbeats.

Tap your foot on the downbeats the entire time, but only count out loud on the accented counts

For the non-accented counts, don’t speak them at all (or say them very quietly).

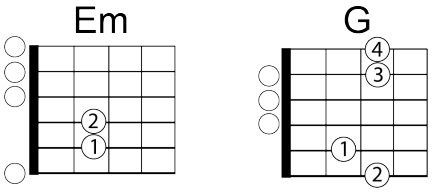


Be very careful at the ending, when you repeat: you’ll need to perform two accents in a row!

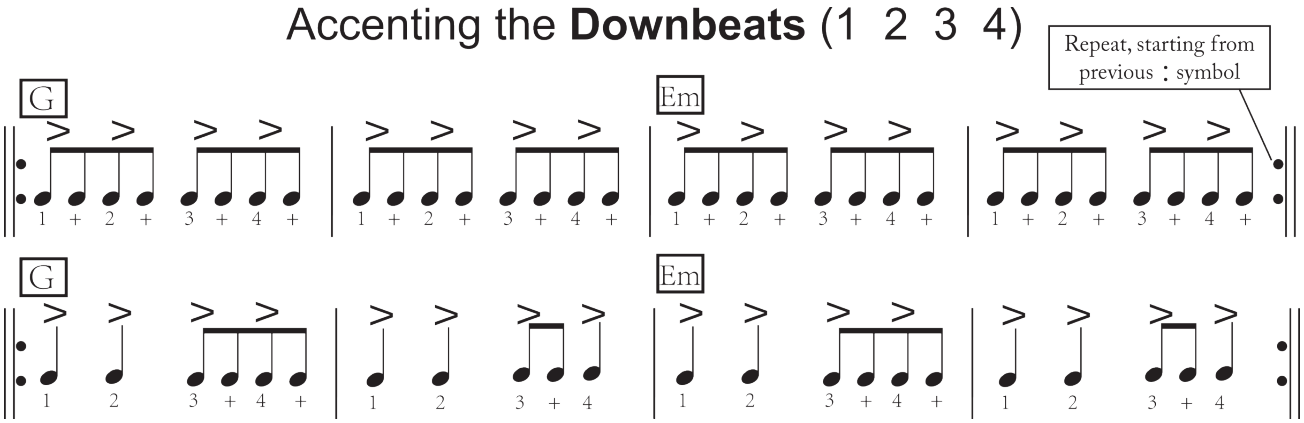
Exercises (Video #4.1)

For each exercise, tap your foot on each beat (1 2 3 4) and count each strum out loud. Say accented counts louder than the surrounding counts.

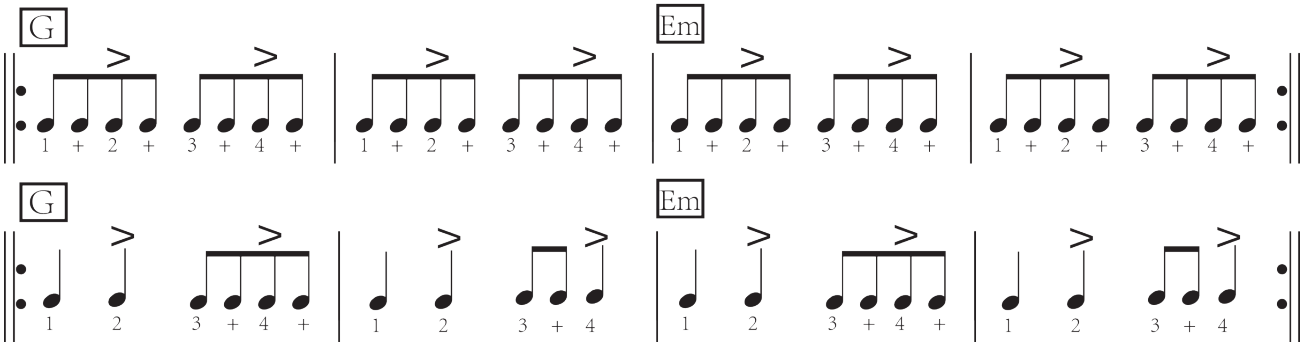
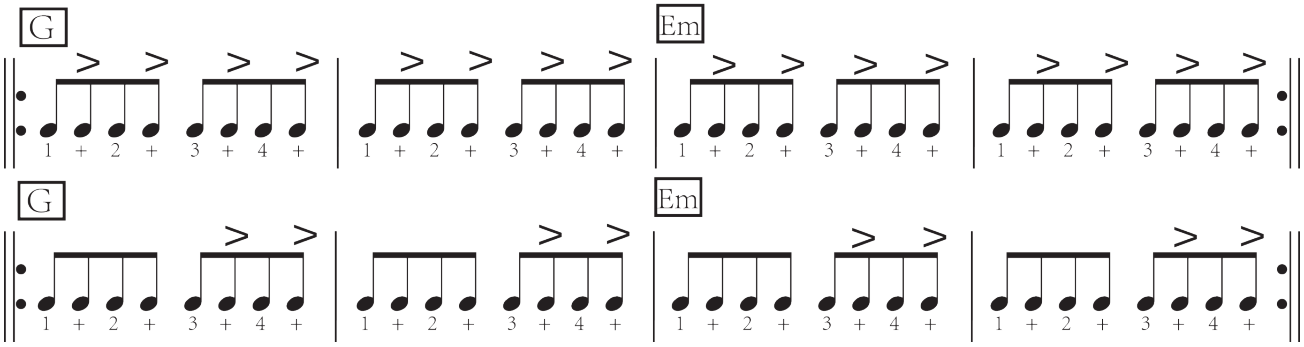
Play each line twice, then move on to the next line. Play the two chords, G and Em, as indicated in these charts:



Accenting the **Downbeats** (1 2 3 4)



Accenting the **Backbeat** (2 + 4)



Accenting the **Upbeats** (syncopation)